Bagbear

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Chapter 1

The Monster at the Bottom of the Garden

Down at the bottom of Bobby Banks' garden; past the woodshed and the cabbage patch, past the rough grass and then past the blackberry bushes, Bobby had spotted a large dark shape. It looked half as big as a house and no one, absolutely no one but he, had noticed it. Yet he had seen it every night for a week.

At the very same time of night, he would wake up and go and look out of his bedroom window.

It had first happened on Sunday night; he had been happily asleep and dreaming when all of a sudden he found himself wide awake, just sitting there, wondering what to do with himself. He got up and pulled back the curtains to look at the stars - Then he saw it.

The thing was dark and round in the moonlight and he could see it clearly against the night sky.

It moved up and down as if it were alive and breathing, in and out, in and out.

And so it went on happening again and again, every night that week.

He had to find out what it was. He just had to! But every morning there was no sign of it and he, very sensibly, stayed well away.

But this morning, he finally decided to go down to the Blackberry bushes and look for footprints; anything, that would give him a clue to what it had been. Slowly and carefully he crept around and peered into every bush. Hardly a blade of grass was out of place and there was no sign that any night monster had been there. Rather disappointed, he was about to leave when he noticed something odd. Where were all the berries? Not one was left. Last week, the Blackberry bush had been heavy with fruit, about to ripen. Now it sat there totally empty! His heart missed a beat and his eyes widened. That's it! He thought. Something is going on!

But how could a creature that size, just disappear without a trace? He stayed looking, biting his lip and turning round and round to examine every inch of the place. Only one thing was out of place. Some grass around

the old rabbit hole was pushed back. Rabbits, gigantic rabbits? He laughed at the thought and shook the picture out of his mind. No, this needed a real detective to investigate. He decided it was time to ask his parents for help.

When he talked to his mother the first time about it, she hardly even listened. Just smiled and nodded and said very little. So he tried again the next day.

"Will you go and look?" he asked his mum. "It's just past the bushes."

"If I have the time," said his mother and carried on with her work.

"But you said that last night," said Bobby.

What would it take to get her to believe him? How could he get her to take him seriously, he thought.

He tugged at her arm again. "It would only take a minute mum, honestly."

His mother paused and looked down at him.

"No, not now Bobby! Why don't you go and have a look yourself?"

"But I'm the one who has seen it. Now I want you to see it; and anyway, it won't be there, not **now**. I told you it never comes out during the **day**."

"All right, all right, I see I'm never going to get any peace until I've looked at your "monster. I'll have a look down there before I go to bed. Now is **that** all right?"

"No that's too early, you must go in the middle of the night. If you set your alarm clock for about 3 o'clock in the morning that would do it." said Bobby hopefully.

"3 o'clock in the morning!" His mum took off her rubber gloves and hung them on the dish rack with a quick flick.

"If you think I'm going to trudge about in the pitch dark looking for monsters in the middle of the night! Oh! What an imagination!"

"You see! You don't believe me" he sighed.

"Bobby Banks! You'll drive me crazy! Now off you go and play and no more of this nonsense!" She shooed him out of the kitchen and went on with her work.

It was absolutely no use, thought Bobby, no use at all. Nobody would do anything. Now it was all up to him. Unless he did something about it, the mystery would never be solved. He would just have to prove to everyone that there **was** something there, and there was only one way he could do that. He would go and take a picture of it, all by himself. Then they would believe him. They would have to. It would take a lot of planning but it would be worth it just to find out.

And that is just what he did!

Chapter 2

All Detectives need a Plan

He didn't bother to mention it to anyone again but now he could not stop thinking about it. Even when he was at school, he thought about it during class instead of concentrating on his lessons.

"Bobby Banks! Pay attention!" shouted the teacher.

Bobby sighed. He finished his sums and put a piece of paper inside his exercise book. He started writing down all the things he would need and what he would do that night.

1. Torch from the kitchen drawer.
2. Camera and flash light.
3. Large stick for defending myself.
4. Spare back-door key from shelf.
5. Leave a warm dressing gown over the end of my bed.
6. Have my slippers handy on chair.

Miss Fotherington looked up and saw him working hard.

"I'm glad to see you have snapped out of your daydream Bobby," she said as she watched him writing away furiously. "

“Bring me your sums," she said.

He looked up quickly and snatched the paper from his book before closing it and getting up, very slowly.

As he walked up to her, Bobby stuffed the note into in his pocket.

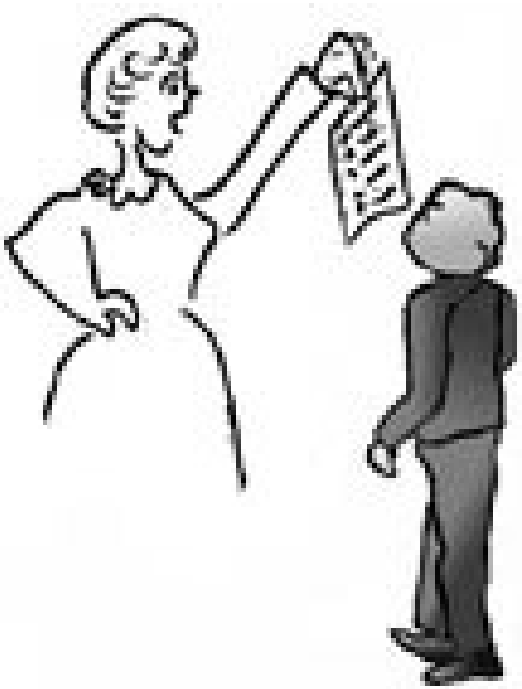
"And what was that?" she said.

"Oh nothing Miss" said Bobby, pushing the paper down as hard as he could.

”Let me see it" she said and held out her hand.

Bobby withdrew the crumpled list and handed it to Miss Fotherington. "It's nothing Miss, honest," he said.

She slowly smoothed it onto the desk and read it. It didn't make any sense.



"A Large stick for defending myself!" she read out. "What kind of list is this!"

All the class were looking at him and giggling.

"It's nothing Miss. I told you, I'm just writing about things that I might keep in my room at night." said Bobby, trying his best to look cheerful.

"What do you want a stick for?"

"I like to be ready for anything Miss; I mean, a robber might break in or something."

"And the camera? Is that to take a picture of him?"

Bobby thought quickly. "Emm, that is to catch Matilda, our cat, she jumps on my bed. I want to prove to mum that it isn't me that makes the marks on the cover."

She handed it back to him and eyed him suspiciously. He did not look worried, she thought, not even a little bit and she knew his habit of inventing wild stories.

"Sorry miss," he said sweetly giving her his best smile.

She sighed and shook her head. "You just keep your mind on your work Bobby Banks," and handing him back his paper she said. "Now put that away."

"Yes Miss," said Bobby and returned to his seat.

Later in the playground, some of his friends wanted to know what it was all about but he decided to keep it a secret. He knew that things have a habit of getting out of hand. Someone, or something, might stop his plan and then he would never find out what it was.

During tea that evening he hardly said a word.

"You're very quiet," said his Mum.

"Just thinking," said Bobby but he never told her anything; not a word.

. . .

He spent the evening collecting all the things on his list and put them in his room. When everything was ready he got changed for bed without the slightest bit of trouble. His mother and father were very pleased with him and asked him if he wanted to stay up for an extra half an hour.

"No thanks," said Bobby. Nothing must be different, he thought, everything must be the same as usual so he would wake up at exactly the right time in the middle of the night. Then he would look out of the window; then he would see the monster. Then he would be ready!

Chapter 3

The First Encounter

Bobby's eyes flickered open. He looked at the clock on his bedside table. Yes, it was just the same as usual, 2.30 am and everyone was asleep. He crept to the window and looked out.

Just as he had expected, the dark shape of the Night Monster loomed high above the Blackberry bushes. If he was a little frightened, he didn't show it. "Yes!" he thought, "this is it!" He gathered his list of things and put on his slippers and dressing gown.

Quietly, like a little mouse, he crept down-stairs and opened the back door. Matilda, the cat, was the only one to see him and she dashed through the cat flap. She was already sitting on the step outside when Bobby came out. She watched him until he was half way down the garden path, then decided to follow. Suddenly she stopped as she saw the huge dark shape in front of them.

Bobby couldn't stop her. She let out a fearsome screech and bolted away. It was too late, the creature had heard and had started moving. It didn't go in any direction but rather, it seemed to be sinking into the ground behind the bushes.

Bobby dashed forward, it was getting away. He could hear the rustle of the leaves as it brushed past them. He flung himself through the bushes and there before him was the back end of the monster itself.

The front end had already gone, having disappeared down-a rabbit hole. Now the rest of the body was changing shape like a long thin balloon and was attempting to follow. Bobby did a very brave thing. With no thought of danger, he caught hold of its tail and started to pull as hard as he could.

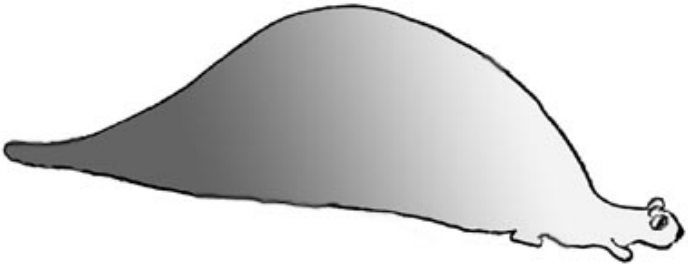
"No you don't," he shouted and walked in the other direction, dragging the tail over his shoulders.

“Woha! What am I doing!’ he said to himself. He dropped it quickly and stood back. But nothing happened. The tail just stayed there, not moving. Bobby bent down and picked up his stick and held it high above his head. Still nothing happened.

"Come out," he shouted. "Come out at once!"

The tail began to tremble and, inch by inch, began to move backwards. Bobby moved backwards too, with his stick raised high and his muscles tight. He stopped thinking. His excitement at finally finding out the truth, made him ready for anything. Bit by bit it backed out of the rabbit hole and as it did, the long thin shape filled up like a balloon till it was half the size of a house a. It was standing right there in front of him, floating an inch above the ground. Bobby backed even further away and swished the stick through the air, backwards and forwards, side to side.

"All right," he said "Now I'll show them!"



The monster's head was so very small, compared to the rest of his body, and it was hanging down sadly. The big creature just stood there, hardly daring to look Bobby straight in the eye. "This is my chance," thought Bobby and slowly and carefully put his stick against the bush and took out his camera.

He was just about to take a picture when he noticed something odd. Large drops of water were falling all over the place and it wasn't raining. He took the camera away from his eyes and held out his hand. A big wet splash of something dropped right on to it. He looked up and saw that the water was coming from the monster's eyes. It looked so terribly sad and upset.

"Oh you poor thing," said Bobby and put down his camera. The creature wiped his eyes with one of his furry brown paws and sniffed.

"I'm sorry," it said in a rather mellow voice.

"Wow! It TALKS!" whispered Bobby. "Who are you?" said Bobby, more kindly "and what are you doing in our garden?"

The monster stopped crying and looked down at Bobby.

"I'd love to tell you," it said and tried its best to smile. "I haven't spoken to anyone for ages. May I come down?"

"Yes," said Bobby and smiled a little

"Is it ok if I let some air out first?"

"Ehmm", yes I suppose so," said Bobby, not wanting to ask what he meant.

There was a soft whistling sound and the gigantic creature began to shrink. It seemed to be the most natural thing in the world to the animal. He shuffled around, all the time getting smaller and smaller.

When the shrinking had stopped, what was left was an animal which looked like a very large brown teddy bear with a tail a bit like a kangaroo. He watched the creature shuffle around, until it finally settled and sat quietly in front of him. "That's better," it said

It sat upright, its paws-on its tummy and looked at him. It didn't look at all frightening now but rather soft and cuddly. Apart from the lovely brown ears and soft paws, there were no bumpy bits in the entire animal. After all that shrinking, Bobby had expected to see something very wrinkly, but the creature was perfectly round and smooth.

"Well," said Bobby "are you ready now?"

"Indeed I am. I am longing to share my story with someone. The rabbits have been angry with me because I used their burrow and even if I could talk to them I doubt if they would be interested."

"Tell me, then," said Bobby impatiently "Who, err....what, are you?"

"I'm a Bagbear," said the creature "from Bannaboo."

"Where is that?" said Bobby "and what is a Bagbear? I've never heard of one."

"It would take too long to tell you everything. Can I show you? We have a different way of talking. Words can be such a nuisance sometimes. They lose bits of what they should say when they fly through the air from one person to the other. Don't you think?"

"I suppose so. I've never really thought about it. But how else can you tell me?"

"I will show you," said the Bagbear. "You sit there and I sit here, then we both close our eyes and ....." Bobby stopped him.

You're not going to trick me?" said Bobby. "You are not just going to vanish as soon as I close my eyes!"

"Of course not! But you will have to trust me. Please do, please let me show you, I really do want to talk to you. Now that I have got over the fright of seeing you."

Bobby laughed. "You got a fright! Seeing me!" He sat up a bit straighter.

The creature frowned a little and spoke very softly to him. "Bagbears stay away from humans. It's not safe." He stopped and smiled. "I can tell you are different though. I really would like to be your friend."

"All right then," said Bobby warily "There, I've closed my eyes. Now what?"

"Now I will tell you my story," said the Bagbear

"Why do I have to close my eyes?" said Bobby.

"Because you are going to see a lot of pictures."

"With my eyes closed!" said Bobby and opened them for a second to look at the creature who was still sitting beside him, very still but with his eyes tight shut.

"Ok", said Bobby and closed his eyes again.

Then suddenly he started seeing something.

It was the bagbear's story. It came in clear pictures, just like a film.

This is what Bobby saw - You can 'picture it' too if you like.

Chapter 4

Seeing Things Differently

Bobby's mind began to fill with more and more pictures, as though he was looking out of his own eyes because he could turn his head and see everything around him.

He could see he was in a garden but it was nothing like his own garden. This was a lovely sunny hillside. He felt himself rise slowly above the ground while being rocked to and fro on something warm. He looked around and saw that he was resting on a cushion of warm air. It felt really good. Now he started to rise higher until he was floating in the sky above the trees, flowers and the green hills. It was lovely, just like being inside a computer game. He was enjoying it all, and everything was great. He could see the hills moving further and further away but there was nothing to worry about for the stream of air was going round and round and slowly he would come back to the same spot again and again. It was a good, peaceful feeling. Floating and swaying in the warm air. He seemed to be lying on his back with his hands resting on his tummy. He began to feel sleepy and time was passing. He seemed half asleep or half awake, but

in a second a sudden jolt shattered the dreamy feeling. He was moving like a rocket into the cold air above him. He gave a little shiver. Yes he was still in the bagbear's story. He gritted his teeth as he felt everything that the bagbear had felt.

Up and up he went and the air got colder and colder. It was beginning to swirl faster in a tight, circle. He struggled to free himself but it was moving too fast. Up and up he continued to go. Round and round, faster, faster; colder, colder, till he felt it gripping him like a rope and he was helpless, even to struggle. Bits of trees and earth seemed to be mixed with the air now. He felt a dull thud on the side of his head and then everything went black.

Bobby was just about to open his eyes when he realised that the story was still being told. He waited patiently and then the pictures started coming back. Everything was fuzzy at first. Pictures came and went, like someone blinking in a strong light. Then suddenly there it was. The sky, the clouds and when he looked down below, the choppy waters of the sea. He felt the bagbear starting to panic and twist and turn over and look around properly. Gone were the rolling hills, the trees, the warm gentle breezes and the feeling of peace. There was a biting wind and above him, were mountains of grey clouds thundering along above a cruel dark sea.

Up and up he flew, to escape the salty spray of sea water that must have woken him up. What had happened? Had something knocked him out? How far had he floated? He had no idea. The dark clouds streamed past him like a watery mist. He went above them, coming out on the topside where it was colder, but the sun shone in a bright

blue sky. He stopped and looked around. There was an eerie silence. Not even a bird in sight. Where was he?

It is difficult to describe, in any kind of words, what happened next. It was a great jumbled mass of feelings, changing from being happy to being sad; giving up then trying **really** hard again and back to being really really frightened. One feeling followed another as Bobby experienced **for himself** what the **bagbear** had felt as he searched and searched for his way back home.

Now it was dark again and he began to see the outline of hills. To Bobby, these hills looked strangely familiar. Yes, he recognised them. They were very close to his own home. There was the valley, just a mile or so away, and now he was nearly over his own house, the Banks' own house. But what he was feeling was the bagbear's thoughts and everything that was going through HIS head at that time. He felt the bagbear's disappointment, tiredness, exhaustion, sadness, nothing familiar, nothing like home just a great lost feeling.

Once again he saw that the bagbear was still as lost as ever. He began to sink down, down.... down... lower and lower till he landed on the soft earth. He looked around and Bobby knew that he was looking at the space behind the blackberry bushes in Bobby's very own garden. In the Bagbear's thoughts there was none of this nice home feeling, there was only a feeling of strangeness and a sense of danger. He was hopelessly lost and alone in a strange new land.

The pictures stopped. That was it, it was all over, now Bobby knew exactly how the creature had come to be there

in his back garden; caught inside a whirlwind, knocked unconscious and blown away till he landed right here.

Bobby opened his eyes and looked the creature. He didn't have to say another word. They both sat there in silence for some time.

"So that's it." said the creature softly.

"Oh well. I'm glad you told me. I don't know what to say. I wish I hadn't shouted at you," said Bobby.

They were both silent again, just taking everything in.

"That's all right," said the Bagbear. "I think I must have given you a fright too."

"What is your name by the way?" said Bobby, getting back some of his courage.

"It's a Bagbear name, you couldn't possibly pronounce it."

"Well can I give you a name? Can I call you Baggy?"

"Why not? That sounds just right to me." it said, attempting a little smile. "You are the first human who has ever seen us and I hope, now that you know we exist, it will not be the end of us." .

"Why should it be?" said Bobby.

"I don't know? That's what the grown-ups say. I am just a young Bagbear, I can't tell really.'"

"I suppose I can guess," said Bobby. "Some humans wouldn't leave you in peace anymore. They would put you in a zoo or something."

"What's a zoo?"

"Never mind," said Bobby, "but you don't have to worry

about me, I've decided to help you. Somehow, I am going to get you back home, even if I have to take you there myself."

"Do you know where Bannaboo is?" said Baggy excitedly.

"No," said Bobby "But, now we can look for it together."

"I'll get lost again." said Baggy sorrowfully "We'll both get lost."

"No we won't. What you need is a good navigator and here I am.

Bobby thought for a while.

Here's my plan," he said at last. "If I can come with you for a bit, I'll make a map as we go along. And," he paused for a while as he worked out more of the plan. "If we have not found your home, we'll try again in another direction. We'll keep the maps to tell us where we have already tried. Then, when we do find your home, you can bring me back here. The map will be yours to keep and you will know exactly how to get back. Now, how does that sound?"

"Marvellous!" said Baggy. "Climb on and we'll go right now."

"No. I must get a pencil and paper," said Bobby "Wait right there I'll be back in a minute"."

He dashed off, leaving Baggy standing, smiling in the moonlight.

Chapter 5

Look out for Matilda

Baggy settled down to wait for Bobby to return not knowing that Matilda was watching him from beside the bushes. She had seen Bobby leave but did not follow him. Instead she crept out of the bushes and padded silently up to Baggy who had puffed himself up to get ready for the flight.

Matilda sat down and looked at him properly.

"What did it taste like?" she thought.

"Was it a very big mouse?"

"What would it do if I jumped on its back?"

"Could I possibly stick my claws through that brown fur?" And on and on she went until her mind was dizzy with more questions. She stopped thinking because Baggy had turned around and was looking straight at her. She stood her ground. This was HER garden and no oversized mouse was going to scare HER off!

Baggy was trying hard not to panic. This animal meant

business. He could nearly hear her thoughts, shouting at him to get out of her garden.

Most of all he knew that she had claws which were probably very sharp. He knew she was planning something and he sensed her muscles tightening and getting ready to spring. But what could he do? He had promised the boy to stay right there. If he moved, he might lose his new friend for ever.

"Go away," he shouted "Shoo!"

Her claws came out and her back arched and then the sound of running footsteps made her move back. Bobby was coming back, running and panting down the path towards them. Baggy relaxed.

"You naughty cat," called Bobby in a whispered sort of way. "Off you go!"

She turned and ran off.

With a little bit of help from Baggy, Bobby climbed onto the brown furry back and felt himself sliding gently into a perfectly sized dip just behind Baggy's head. On either side, flaps of fur folded over him; holding him tight and keeping him safe and secure.

As they rose into the air, Baggy called back to him. "Thank you for saving me, It would have been terrible if she had punctured me."

"What would have happened?" asked Bobby.

"I wouldn't have been able to fly for weeks? It's a great problem for Bagbears and our doctors are always trying to find new cures for it."

"Then we won't let that happen to you." said Bobby sternly.

. . .

Bobby made himself nice and comfortable. He snuggled deeper into Baggy's soft brown fur and then popped his head out of the opening. He found that he could look around very easily so he took his pad of paper and laid it right in front of him and got his pencil ready to start drawing.

They rose slowly, without a sound and Bobby let out a small gasp as he watched his house and garden growing smaller and smaller.

The moon was bright and full and the silvery light made the scenery even easier to map. A hill here, a river there, a railway line, a town and then Baggy rose even higher. Bobby's job became easier. Now he only took note of very special outlines such as a whole range of hills or the shape of the coastline as it cut into the land. It was a wonderful experience. He was completely cradled in Baggy's fur, only his head was peeping out of the hollow. It was a bit like looking out of the cockpit of a plane that had been made to fit just him alone.

On and on sailed the great dark shape. No one noticed them because from the ground they looked exactly like a drifting cloud.

"That's the English Channel," shouted Bobby suddenly.

"What does that mean?" said Baggy.

"It means we are leaving England, and France is just over there, look!"

In the distance they could see the outline of Northern France but it wasn't long before they were well inland and they were crossing over miles and miles of flat countryside with nothing much for Bobby to take note of. Then, all of a sudden, Baggy seemed to jump for joy.

"What is it?" called Bobby.

"Look, over there. It looks a bit like that."

Baggy was pointing to some high mountains.

"Those are the French Alps." called Bobby.

Nearer and nearer they came and as they did, Baggy got less and less excited till at last he slowed down, completely.

He shook his head sadly and stopped altogether.

"No, it's not....." he said, almost whispering. "It's not my home."

"Never mind," said Bobby "We'll try again another night."

Baggy nodded and they turned around to go back.

The trip home was quick and very silent.

They landed softly among the Blackberry bushes and Matilda darted off as she saw them coming.

"Don't worry, we'll keep looking, I promise." said Bobby. "I really do!"

"You're very kind, I shall miss you all day. Will you come back tomorrow night?"

"Of course I will, silly!" said Bobby. He laughed and patted Baggy's drooping head.

"I wouldn't miss it for the world. Now you get some sleep. At least now I know you live in a mountain. That should make things easier. We will just go and look at all the mountains and sooner or later we are bound to find yours."Baggy smiled sleepily. "All right Bobby. See you tomorrow."

Bobby gave him a hug before he ran off and Baggy yawned and started disappearing down his hole.

Under the Blackberry bush, Matilda's eyes were watching every move.

She purred in satisfaction, she was good at waiting, waiting for the right

time, the precise moment to strike. She unsheathed her claws at the thought and swished her tail in anticipation of the great pounce. .

Her moment would come, she thought, and settled down to wait.

Chapter 6

Bobby Finds the Answer

In the morning Bobby wasted no time getting dressed. He dashed downstairs and ran straight out to the garden.

Good morning Baggy!" he shouted down the rabbit hole. There was silence for a minute or two, then a brown head peeped out. Baggy looked up at him through glazed, sleepy eyes.

"Good morning." he said and nearly fell asleep again on the spot with his head still poking out of the rabbit hole.

"Just wanted to tell you I haven't forgotten," said Bobby. "I'm going right now, this minute, to make some plans at school."

"Good, good," mumbled Baggy and let out a deep, rumbling snore.

"I think you had better get back to bed." said Bobby and tried to push him back into his hiding place.

"See you later." said Baggy and disappeared.

Bobby laughed and ran up the path. He barged into the kitchen from the garden, still smiling and happy.

"What were you doing out there?" said his mother who was putting his breakfast on the table.

He was about to say nothing but then he had a great idea. Surely this was the best time to tell them the whole truth. Bobby took a deep breath and blurted out Bagbear's story.

He spoke so fast, that he jumbled up half his words but he kept on talking because he was really excited to tell her absolutely everything. He got quite out of breath by it all and slowed down as he came the end. "And now," he said, taking a gulp of air, "he is asleep in the rabbit hole." He took another deep breath and waited for her marvellous response.

All through his story she had smiled and nodded her head, as people often do when they are not really listening or don't think it's terribly important. Now, she wasn't saying anything. He waited patiently.

She pulled out a chair and told him to sit down and get on with his breakfast. "I didn't ask you what you were dreaming about last night," she said, shaking her head. "I don't know where you get all this from. What an imagination! I wish I could dream like that!." She smiled and shook her head again.

"Oh you never listen," said Bobby "It's all true, there really is a Bagbear in the garden."

"Bagbear! Snagbear! I don't care what kind of bear it is, if you don't hurry you'll be late for school. Now eat up!"

Bobby was about to try to convince her when he remembered something and stopped. Maybe it was just as well that people didn't know about Baggy. After all the

Bagbears always felt that something dreadful would happen if humans knew about them. Maybe they were right. He let the whole matter drop and went off to school.

When he got there, Bobby went straight to the library to borrow a book on the mountains of the world. It took him only ten minutes to realise that there were ***many*** more of them than he had imagined. He checked out the first one or two and then sighed and slowly closed the book. "It will take years to get round them all," he thought.

That morning in class, they talked about France. "Has anyone been to-France?" said the teacher. Bobby put up his hand.

"Yes Bobby, when did you go and what was it like." said the teacher.

"Err..." said Bobby and stopped. He suddenly realised that he couldn't tell them without giving away his secret.

"I went with a friend," he said quietly "But we didn't stay long, we only went to look at some mountains."

"And did you fly?" said the teacher.

Bobby nodded and said, "yes miss," but wouldn't say another word.

The teacher passed onto someone else.

"Now," she said "we are going to look at some beautiful pictures of mountains."

Bobby looked up; his heart missed a beat and he was full of attention.

The teacher pinned some pictures up on the wall.

"Over the next few weeks we will be talking about far-away places, and these are some of the most far-away places you could find."

"What kind of people live there?" asked a boy called Kevin.

"No, Kevin, nobody lives there," she replied. "And I don't think you would want to go there on holiday." She laughed a bit. "These mountains are so dangerous that there are parts of them that no one has ever reached. Then there are other parts that have only been reached by great explorers."

Bobby was the next one to interrupt. He just could not stop asking questions, even before he got any answers.

"What are they called? How big are they? Could something hide there so that nobody ever knew it existed?

How do you get there? Has anybody said what they found?"

The teacher was rather impressed. "You are showing a lot of interest today Bobby. Well done! I never knew you liked geography so much."

Then she told them that the mountains were called the Himalayas and that they were often thought of as mysterious as well as dangerous. Many strange stories were told by explorers who had climbed up to the very highest of their peaks. Stories of monsters and strange beasts who had left footprints in the snow. Some had even been seen very far away in swirling mists, then they just disappeared into the mountains without trace or sound. At night, some local helpers would hear noises echoing through the icy air. Because of all these stories, they were frightened and superstitious so it was sometimes difficult for explorers to get local help.

"A place-to keep well away from, if you ask me!" said Miss Fotherington smugly.

Bobby smiled to himself "That sounds like the sort of place I'm looking for," he thought

At playtime Bobby asked his teacher if she would draw him a map of how to get to those mountains.

"How to get there! Why would you want to do that?"

"I want to look them up on the map. They sound really great... I want to see where they are. Just to know"

She laughed but Bobby didn't stop.

"Please Miss, which bit of them is the most far-away, the most difficult to get to and where absolutely NOBODY lives?"

Miss Fotherington stopped laughing and smiled. The boy looked so excited by it. How could she let him down. She believed in encouraging her students. "Ok Bobby. I will make a map for you. Now off you go."

During the break, she went to the computer and found an excellent map of that area. After playtime, Bobby ran to see what she made for him and, to his delight, found it was exactly what he needed. It looked exactly like a route map marked with a nice clear pencil line which lead right from their town straight to the Himalayas. He took the map from Miss Fotherington's hand as though it was a piece of solid gold.

"Thank you," he said "Thank you very much."

Miss Fotherington smiled and shook her head as she watched him dash off, holding the map tightly in his hand.

How he was looking forward to telling Baggy the good news. He couldn't wait.

As soon as he got in from school, he ran down to the bottom of the garden and shouted down the rabbit hole. The words

tumbled out as he rambled on telling Baggy about the mountains and the tales of mysterious 'monsters'.

Eventually Baggy got the whole story, or enough of it anyway, to get just as excited as Bobby. so that he nearly came out in broad daylight.

Bobby pushed him gently back into the hole and told him to be careful.

"I'm going to pack my lunch box." said Bobby "It will be a long journey."

"I'll be waiting," shouted Baggy from far inside the hole "This is it! OOOOH..." he said excitedly "This is it!"

"Be ready then'. At midnight." said Bobby and went off to prepare.

Chapter 7

Off to Bannaboo

Night time came. His mother and father were asleep and 'the great adventure' was about to begin. Silently, very silently, so as not to wake anyone, even the cat, he got dressed, put on his jacket, hat and scarf, took his lunchbox and crept outside.

Baggy was waiting impatiently, doing a little dance to stop himself from taking off with excitement.

"Let's go, let's go," he said and Bobby got on his back. He tucked his lunch box into the hollow with him and got out the map that the teacher had drawn. "O.K. Let's go," he whispered to Baggy.

Up they went into the air. Bobby gave the directions clearly and the flight went on without a hitch. They were both so happy that Baggy started singing. From somewhere, deep inside Baggy's air-filled body, a soft music started filtering out. It was a soft, beautiful sound, a bit like a flute. No, actually, it was more like *several* flutes, all playing in harmony to create a perfect song. On top of that, Bobby could hear

Baggy humming and hooting to the music as they went along. Of course, Bobby could not resist also trying to sing along and he invented words to go with the strange tune.

"Oh we are off to find the place.....We are going to find it now.....Baggy Bear is going home ..... and we are sailing through the air..."

They both laughed and went on singing and humming.

Down on the ground below them, the people who happened to look up, only saw a big dark cloud sailing along. No one thought there was anything odd or different about it, but they did wonder where the music was coming from.

They sailed on through the night, without one single problem. Normally, in our world, it would have taken many, many more hours to travel the distance that Baggy travelled that night but bagbears have another special trick . Once they know where they are going, they can 'hop' forwards and arrive instantly in a new place, just seconds after leaving the other place. It happened like that several times during the journey. Bobby would suddenly notice that everything went blurred and then, when he could see clearly again, everything below him looked different. Baggy, in the meantime, just went on singing so, of course, there was nothing for Bobby to worry about. He relaxed and enjoyed the ride and everything went beautifully.

The singing suddenly stopped and Baggy became really quiet for a few minutes. He was looking at some distant hills that were drawing nearer and nearer. Suddenly he seemed to recognise something.

"This is it, this is it'" he shouted.

"Are you sure," said Bobby.

"I can feel it, I can sense it, the air feels right, everything is right." Baggy was half squealing, half chuckling as he babbled on. "There's no place that feels like home. I just know we are getting near."

"All right, slow down and let's look carefully," said Bobby, pulling himself up to get a better view.

They searched and searched for what felt like ages. Then Baggy shouted, "Yes, yes, I'm right!" then veered right then left and swooped in a tight circle.

Bobby stayed quiet. All he could see was white snow and dark mountain rock. Secretly, he actually began to worry a little. It looked really dangerous down there and he began to wonder if this was a such good idea after all.

Then, quite suddenly, they spotted it! Oh what a surprise! Right in the middle of all these rocks and snowy peaks, he could see a long, wide green valley. Around the valley were soft rolling green hills and around them were the tall, snowy mountains on every side. It looked like a green island in a jagged white sea.

"No wonder it has never been found," whispered Bobby.

"I'm home!" called Baggy "We're in Bannaboo!"

Now was the moment of truth. There would be other Bagbears down there , big adult ones and Bobby started wondering if they would be as friendly as Baggy. He tried not to think of it as they began to swoop lower and lower towards Bannaboo.

Meanwhile, in the valley below, all was very quiet. If Baggy had got a shock when he was carried off, then the Bagbears he left behind had got an even greater one. How

awful it had been for them to have watched helplessly while the whirlwind sucked Baggy higher and higher into its centre. They saw him being struck unconscious by an uprooted tree and then being carried away limply further and further till at last he was hidden by the swirling clouds of dust and rain.

They could not even go to his rescue for a fierce wind came immediately after the whirlwind and they had to rush to find safe hiding places in the caves.

When the unusual storm was over, they came outside to look around. Never in all their history had such an awful thing happened. They wandered around feeling stunned, then some strong grown-ups flew off in every direction over the mountains around them to look in peaks and crevasses for Baggy. After days of searching, they found nothing. Now, no one thought he was still alive.

They were still in a state of shock and not much talking or singing had gone on since the day of the storm.

So it was, that Baggy and Bobby landed in a hushed village. Everyone was indoors doing their work quietly even though it was now well into the morning. Bobby got down and they both stood in silence and looked around.

"Where is everybody?" asked Bobby, at last.

"I don't know," said Baggy "Hello!" he called, and the word echoed around the hills till it faded away and all was quiet again.

After that. things began to happen very quickly. A head peeped out of a door in the rock. Then another, and another, then twenty, thirty and then a great hullaballoo started.

What a noise! Bobby had to put his fingers in his ears as

the bears got excited. Bagbears make the most amazing noises in their own language and when they get excited - oh well, there is nothing to describe what goes on then.

Baggy was surrounded in seconds. He came down to his normal size and danced around with the others as they hugged and kissed him. Some of them puffed themselves up and floated up in the air in sheer delight.

The sky was soon thick with bagbears, floating and flying about. Bobby couldn't help laughing at it. He was standing there laughing and giggling when he was picked up by one of the biggest bagbears of all.

"Wow!" he cried, as the great furry arm surrounded his waist and carried him off, high into the air.

Bagbears communicate very quickly and Baggy had already told everybody the whole story. It was Baggy's own dad who lifted Bobby off his feet. He was so grateful to him that he tossed him in the air and caught him again, several times, just as they do to baby bagbears. Then he gave him a great hug, as soft and tender a hug as he had ever felt, and carried him gently to the ground.

Have you ever eaten Tikermottle-Glory, Heuch Buns with Heuchberry sauce and Fizzing Filliat Juice? No? Well neither had Bobby but by the time the morning was over he had tasted them all and lots more. Bobby's lunch box caused a bit of a stir and excitement, especially his peanut butter cookies which went down a treat. They talked and talked and Bobby learned so much about them that it would take another whole book to put it down in writing.

He learned that they don't really speak any other language but their own but, because of a very special gift

they have, anyone who listened to them could understand what they were saying.

He was shown part of their city which, surprisingly enough, was not outside but inside. All the mountains around them were riddled with bagbear towns and villages. They went even as far as the great Mount Everest itself. The bagbears of that region were mostly white, he was told, and occasionally they had come across human mountaineers who seemed to run in great fear from them.

They never understood why but it was generally accepted that humans and bagbears weren't quite ready to meet. "That is a pity," said Bobby "but I think you are right and I'll keep your secret safe. I promise you."

"We know Bobby, we know we can trust you and we will always be your friend."

"Can I come back some day?" said-Bobby excitedly.

"Why don't you stay now for a while?"

"But what about my dad and mum? They don't even know I'm here!"

There was silence. The bagbears looked a little shocked. They had not realized this and questioned Baggy. When Baggy told them that this was a secret mission by Bobby and that he had promised to return him that very night, they looked worried.

"You are not going to leave us again?" said Baggy's mum. "What if you are lost? What if something happens to you, out there in the human world."

No one answered her because she already knew that there was no real question of Baggy not returning Bobby to his home after he had done so much for him. She just looked at the ground and Baggy gave her a hug.

"Of course I'll be back. Just another day or two and I'll be home for good."

"Yes, of course you will," said his mother, trying to cheer up.

Bobby looked at his watch. It would soon be morning in England and they had a lot of flying to do. "We've got to hurry or you won't be able to hide. Quickly Baggy we must go."

Baggy gave his dad and mum another quick hug.

"Don't worry, everything is all right now, I know my way back, so nothing much can happen now."

The bagbears did their best to look at ease and tried not to frighten Baggy who, after all, was a very brave Bagbear to leave his home again after such a short stay. They waved and blew them kisses as they rose up into the air and kept smiling till they were well out of sight.

Only then, did Baggy's mum let a big tear fall and then wiped it away quickly, happy to know at least that her son was still alive and well and would be back again very, very soon.

Chapter 8

Matilda Changes Everything

The journey back home did not take quite as long as Bobby thought it would. It seems he and Baggy made more of those special 'speed jumps' this time. Bobby guessed it was because he now knew, where he was going. How quiet it was though! Bobby hardly said a word except to give a few directions from the map. They were both happy and sad at the same time. On and on they went until they landed, tired and exhausted, among the Blackberry bushes behind Bobby's house. Matilda saw them coming and ran to hide.

"Goodnight," said Bobby as he climbed down. "Have a good rest. I'll see you in the morning." He started walking up the path but turned around and ran back, throwing his arms around Baggy's neck.

"I'm going to miss you SO much," he whispered.

Baggy put a soft furry paw on his back and gave him a gentle squeeze. "We will think of something," he said to Bobby. "Good friends always do. We will think of some-

thing, I'm sure, but tomorrow night I have to get back home."

Bobby smiled. It made him happy to think that Baggy's family would be seeing him again soon.

"Yeh! We'll think of something," he said, sounding a little brighter as he turned to go.

"Goodnight," he called cheerily as he ran up the path. Baggy nodded sleepily and waved to Bobby as he disappeared past the Blackberry bushes.

Just as Bobby reached the back door there was a loud screech.

"Oh No!" he moaned and ran back towards Baggy's hiding place. It all happened so quickly. As he rounded the bushes, he saw Matilda standing right in front of Baggy who was still his full size. Her back was arched and she was ready to pounce.

"Matilda No!" he shouted but it was too late. She made a flying leap but Baggy was too tired and slow to get away.

She dug her claws hard into his fur and there was a loud pop.

Baggy yelled and Matilda went flying back as the air rushed out.

Bobby ran towards them "Baggy! Baggy!" he shouted.

The lights came on in the house and very shortly the back door opened and Bobby's mum and dad stood on the doorstep, peering out into the darkness.

"What's going on there?" shouted Mr. Banks.

"I'm going right now to call the police," said Mrs Banks.

"It's only me mum?" Bobby shouted back. "Come quickly. Baggy is hurt."

Mr and Mrs Banks ran down the path towards the sound of their son's cries.

Baggy was getting smaller and but by the time they got there he was still the size of a large bus.

"Help!" shouted Bobby's mother as she saw the creature. She lost her footing and stumbled but Mr. Banks caught her just in time as she slowly came to rest on the ground. She stared up at the creature, remembering all the things her son had tried to tell her.

Mr. Banks was a very practical man. What was here, was here and his son was perfectly safe, if just a little upset. "Explain," said his father.

"It's a Bagbear dad and Matilda has hurt him. You have got to help him quickly."

Mrs Banks meanwhile was staring at Baggy and saw the look on his face.

Tears were gushing out of his eyes and he looked more frightened and confused than Mrs Banks herself.

"Oh the poor thing," she said and immediately stopped being worried.

By this time, Baggy had shrunk to his small size.

"We had better get him inside." said Mr. Banks. "I don't think I could explain this to the neighbours."

Mr. Banks lifted Baggy up and carefully put him on his shoulder. He was surprisingly heave for a small animal and he walked carefully up the garden path.

While he did so, Baggy began to moan gently. It was the first time they heard him speak.

"My mother and father will think I am lost again: they

will be waiting every night for me to return, " he was saying tearfully.

"He talks!" Whispered Mrs Banks, and nodded to Bobby, as if to say, "you were right!"

When they brought him into the kitchen and laid him on a rug. Bobby told them the whole story as clearly and as well as he could. Then he explained to them that Baggy would not be able to fly for weeks now unless they found a way to mend-him.

Mr. and Mrs Banks stood there, just looking at him in silence. Both of them understood just how awful that would be for Baggy's parents, especially since he had been very brave to bring Bobby back home. They had no problem in agreeing to do whatever they could to help.

"Right now," said Mr. Banks "It seems to me that you and your friend have had enough adventure for one night. The first thing you do is get a good sleep and your mum and I will do some serious thinking."

"Please daddy, can I take Baggy upstairs with me, he needs some company now."

His father agreed and carried Baggy every so carefully up the stairs to Bobby's room and put him down gently on a rug beside Bobby's bed.

Bobby put one arm out of his covers and rested it on Baggy's back."

Baggy put one arm up to Bobby's bed and slipped it around Bobby.

Side by side boy and Bagbear fell fast asleep for many hours.

. . .

At lunchtime Bobby and Baggy awoke to the noise of a great commotion going on Downstairs. Mr. & Mrs Banks had decided that a vet was the best one to help Baggy so they had called one first thing that morning. By the time they had convinced him that it was not a dog but a rare Himalayan animal, the vet had consulted his partner, the local zoo, the National Geographical Society and they had all come round to have a look.

One by one they had crept upstairs and had taken a quick look at Baggy, still asleep beside Bobby. No one had any idea what to do so they had called

the newspapers to see if they could put out a call for a specialist, someone who had maybe seen a Bagbear before.

There was utter confusion downstairs.

Mr. Banks was trying to smoke his pipe in a corner and get the cup of tea he had made an hour ago.

Mrs Banks was handing round sandwiches and was searching the cupboard for more and more cups and saucers.

Everybody was talking at once.

"There was a case ....I think it was in '67..."

"No...You" are thinking of the hoax in '68. Hillary saw one you know, I think."

"Do you think a zoo would be the right place for this creature."

"We of the humane society wish to disagree!"

"Then there is the feeding."

"Nuts...Chinese grass and nuts....They might even live on air."

"Please, you're standing on my foot I ..."

"Would you like a nice cup of tea?"

. . .

And so it went on and on, and on, and on. Nothing was being decided, they just all wanted to be there when they woke up.

Baggy looked at Bobby as he sat up. "Is it always like this in your house?" he said.

"NEVER!" said Bobby, rubbing his eyes. "It sounds like a party down there," he said and got out of bed.

He crept to the door and peeped out. He shut the door quickly again and gasped. "Oh No! We forgot to tell them to keep it a secret. They've told the whole world!

For a few minutes Baggy and he just stared at each other with open mouths. Not knowing what to think or say.

"No!" they both said together.

"Whatever you do," said Bobby in his best whispered voice, "DON'T let them know you talk!"

What a day it turned out to be. The people from the television turned up.It was in the local newspaper by evening and the National papers had already picked up the story for the next day's big front page.

Bobby had to sit, holding Baggy's hand and tell everything over and over again. Who and what he was and how the air went in and out and how he could change his shape to make him long and thin enough to have hidden down the rabbit hole.

He told them everything but the important things and gave them no hint at all of where he came from. Both of them knew that they had to keep Bannaboo a secret from these people. And by this time, Mr. and Mrs Banks knew it too, and wished they had never called these people for help.

. . .

Up to now they were all doing a good job till who should come in but Miss Fotherington. Would she give it all away?

They needn't have worried. She was far more interested in the cameras than in solving any mystery. In fact she told them that it was highly unlikely that Baggy would ever be able to find his way back as, in her opinion, it was like looking for a needle in a haystack, or a valley in the Himalayas!

"You poor thing!" she said to Baggy "You'll just have to stay here."

She had no idea, and neither had anyone else, that he and Bobby had been there and back already and that her simple map had actually helped them. They certainly did not suspect that they had hidden it away safely for the return journey. She was photographed beside Baggy and Bobby, her brilliant pupil, holding a copy of the last homework he had given in. She stayed around for ages talking to reporters and eventually left after about five cups of Mrs Bank's excellent tea.

When she had gone, there was a visit from a film company who wondered if there was a possibility of getting them to act in their next monster Movie? Then there were more and more questions: from the airport controllers, the police, the foreign press and the army.

By the time everyone had had their chance to ask their questions, it was quite late at night. Baggy, Bobby and both his dad and mum were utterly exhausted and none the wiser about how to mend him. They said goodbye to the last

of the reporters etc and flopped down on the couch in stunned silence.

"I'm sorry," said Mr Banks eventually, "we don't seem to have helped you much."

Baggy smiled sweetly and told them not to worry, they had done their best. All the same, everyone was feeling a bit sad as they thought of Baggy's parents looking up at the night sky, somewhere in Bannaboo, expecting to see their son any moment. They drunk their hot chocolate in complete silence.

Mrs Banks finally sighed and broke the silence. "Well at least," she said quietly, "we can relax now that they're all gone."

Seconds later, there was a soft tapping at the back door.

"Now what?" said Bobby.

Chapter 9

The Professor's Warning

Mrs Banks got up wearily and drew back the kitchen curtain. An old gentleman was standing on the back step clasping a clay pot. She opened the door just a very little and he smiled warmly at her through the crack.

"Excuse me," he said nervously and lifted his hat politely.

"I hope this is not too much of an intrusion. My name is Professor Hubble, I think I might be able to help you."

She paused for a moment, thinking. This was the first person who had said those words.

Mrs Banks stood aside to let him in. Something about him made her feel like trusting him. He seemed to know exactly what he was doing and did not ask any stupid questions. More importantly, he was not carrying a camera.

"Ah yes," he said as he stepped into the kitchen and saw Baggy sitting on the rug. "Just like the one I saw before. And. if I'm not mistaken, you were her cub, the one that was tagging along beside her."

Baggy was very surprised. "No-one has seen a Bag bear!" he said, forgetting he was not supposed to speak.

"Well not that you know of," said the professor and sat down opposite Baggy, placing his hat and his package carefully on the kitchen table.

He was not the least bit surprised at Baggy's outburst and continued to speak.

"Before you ask, I will explain why I have come here, and how I know this little fellow."

Mr. Banks drew up another chair and sat down. "This should be interesting," he thought.

"Now then," said the professor, slowly un-buttoning his overcoat. "A long time ago, while I was on an expedition in the Himalayas, I was separated from the rest of my party. You see, I had stopped to examine a rather interesting rock and then hurried too quickly to catch up. Before I knew it, I lost my footing and I slid all the way down a slope that seemed to go on and on for at least a mile. At the bottom I hit my head on something and was knocked out cold." He stopped the story at that point, nodding his head and smiling. He looked around at everyone and then straight at Baggy.

"I would surely have died," he said seriously and then smiled as he continued. "Had it not been for your dear parent. She carried me, unconscious, back to my party of friends. Then, when no-one was looking, she placed me in a safe place quite close to them and made sure they found me. Because of this, I am alive today."

"But how do you know all this, if you were unconscious?" said Baggy.

"Because I woke up, but was too afraid to let her know. I was scared stiff all the way. I had heard terrible stories from the local people of monsters who hid

in the hills and had no idea how gentle and kind you all were."

The professor went on to tell them how he had wished there were some way he could have thanked her and now he had found a way. Meanwhile, quite by chance, he had invented a new kind of ointment that also sealed cuts, really quickly! He was sure this would mend Baggy's puncture instantly. "Nobody seems to want to use it. They told me they have their own ointments and my one is too simple but I am sure it will work on your friend.

Then he told them the other reason he came and why he had waited for everyone to leave before he knocked on the door.

"You are in great danger dear little Bagbear." The family looked at each other and nodded. They had felt that themselves but did not know why.

"They suspect you do indeed know how to get back to your home and are planning to track you all the way there. They want to find out exactly where the Bagbears live. If they find out, none of you will ever be left in peace again."

The professor was right. The reporters, the zoologists, the army and the rest had got together and decided to plant a microchip inside Baggy when

they tried to mend him. It was quite awful, they had a plan to send tracker planes at a safe distance all the way and relay the signal to satellites. All of this would start when a hidden camera outside would see him leaving the Banks' house.

They knew sooner or later, even if they themselves

didn't manage to mend him, Baggy would be well enough to fly off. It had been decided that a zoo would be picked to study the animals in their own land and maybe capture a few small specimens. They were all so excited about it and thought they had plenty of

time before he left.

However, things had already started happening. A technician, disguised as an telephone company worker, was already at the top of the telegraph pole at the front of the house and a small van, with a telephone company logo, was parked nearby. He had several pieces of equipment dangling from his belt and was busy screwing in some metal holders.

Professor Hubble knew he had to act quickly if Baggy was to escape unseen. Nobody had seen him enter the Banks' house. He had waited till they had all gone and sneaked round to the back door to keep out of sight, especially from the man up the pole.

"Just in case this ointment works," said Bobby, "Don't you think we should

get-Baggy outside. He can't test it in here."

"That's a good idea," said the professor. "Say your goodbyes now, we have to hurry."

Mr and Mrs Banks shook hands with Baggy and thanked him for bringing their son home, safe and sound. They promised, that when all the commotion died down, they

would let Bobby go and stay with Baggy for two whole weeks.

They packed a bag with presents which included two packets of Peanut butter cookies and the recipe of how to cook them, and then they all went outside to the bottom of the garden.

Matilda was hiding in the coal shed, where she had been all day. She was quite upset by all the people coming and going into her owner's house. Or, should I say, HER house! Mrs Banks picked her up, gave her a reassuring pat and took her inside. She gave her a meal and locked her safely in the sitting room where she curled up and went to sleep happily on the easy chair.

The technician, up the telegraph pole at the front of the Banks' house, sent a message to his boss. "They have all gone to bed. There is no movement around the house and all the lights are out." he whispered.

He was still screwing a metal box onto the side of the wood where he was told to put the movement activated camera. Any object (such as a Bagbear) which moved past it would be recorded and send a message back to the headquarters. They would know that the bagbear was on the move and go into action.

Quietly and skilfully they would then follow it all the way back to its lair in this place called Bannaboo. Of course, they would keep a safe distance, well out of sight, but they were not going to let him slip away without a trace. With this, and the tracking device, if they managed to plant it, they would be sure to do the job.

It would look pretty foolish if they couldn't even follow one dumb animal with all their expensive equipment.

The people in charge of this action had strict orders to keep this project out of the public eye. They wanted no objections or fuss. Everyone, including the 'green lot' could say what they wanted once it was over. Nobody knew what they were up to. Or so they thought!

They never knew that, at that very moment, Baggy and all the Banks family were creeping out of the back door and down the garden path.

The family looked around, feeling a bit worried and hardly daring to breathe. Then Bobby pointed to the man on top of the pole. They all stopped and nobody moved a muscle. Their hearts began to beat a little faster as they saw him outlined clearly against the moonlight sky. Bobby gulped. It was obvious he would have a bird's eye view of them as soon as Baggy began to grow.

They could hear the radio of the van which was parked down the side lane but there were so many trees between the van and them that they didn't worry. It was only that man up the telegraph pole who was the real problem.

They crouched down behind a bush and wondered if they were going to miss their last chance. They had to get Baggy away before whatever he was doing was ready. It was now or never!

Mrs Banks whispered "I've got an idea."

"What?" said the professor.

"Why don't we invite the poor man in?"

They all gasped in amazement. Had she gone absolutely mad?

Mrs Banks was not put off. She had a crafty look in her eyes and they all realised that she had a plan.

"I think Matilda needs some company in the sitting room," she said and took one of the packets of peanut butter cookies that she had packed for Baggy and started back up the garden path towards the house.

Chapter 10

Plan of Escape

"Now you all stay very quiet," she said "And don't start anything till I
give the word."

She put the hall light on as though she was pretending to get up and come downstairs and then she put the kitchen light on and made a cup of tea.

She opened the front door wearing her dressing gown over her clothes and shuffling along in her slippers.

"Excuse me," she called to the man on top of the pole. "I couldn't help noticing you there, do you want a cup of tea?"

The man looked a little uncomfortable. He stopped what he was doing and stuck his screwdriver into his pocket with great speed.

"Ahem. . . no . . . I'm fine thanks," he spluttered.

"I'm sure you must be frozen up there," went on Mrs Banks "The phone company shouldn't make you work so late," she said, pretending to know
nothing about what he was really doing.

The man wasn't so worried now, and he didn't see the point of refusing her kind offer. He could do with a cup of tea anyway, he thought, and there was nothing

to keep an eye on till they had mended the creature. If she thought he was a telephone engineer then perhaps it was best to act casually so he wouldn't arouse her

suspicions.

"All right," he said jokingly, "You've persuaded me, I'll be right down."

He shut the box over the uninstalled equipment and slid down the pole. She had no trouble leading him into the sitting-room and putting a tray on the coffee table beside him.

"There you are now, you can make yourself comfortable while I go and check on my son and his new friend." she said.

"I suppose they will be fast asleep?" said the technician.

"They are probably popping off this very minute," she said.

"Popping off?" said the man, looking up in surprise; cookie in his hand and the cup nearly to his lips.

"To sleep! popping off to sleep," said Mrs Banks.

She shuffled a little nervously and yawned, putting her hand to her mouth to pretend she was just about to go to bed.

"Are you sure I am not in the way?" said the man. "I'll finish this quickly and get on with my job."

"Just you sit there," said Mrs Banks with a smile "and I'll go and check on everything and come back for the cup later. Make yourself comfortable."

"I will, thank you," said the engineer, not suspecting a thing.

Mrs Banks closed the door and very, very quietly slipped away out of the 'back door and back down the garden path. She put both thumbs up when she came near them. To tell the truth she, was getting very excited on Baggy's behalf and couldn't wait for him to be able to see his parents again and be back home, safe and sound.

"All clear now," she whispered and crouched down beside them.

"Will it. work quickly Professor?" asked Mrs Banks. "I'm not sure how long I can keep him there without arousing everyone's suspicions."

"This ointment should mend the hole in Baggy's sack instantly. It will be up to Baggy then."

"Will it hurt?" said Baggy.

"Of course not! It will make you feel as good as new. Stay still now."

Baggy nodded. He was a little bit nervous and screwed up his eyes as theprofessor applied the ointment.

The Bank family stood well back. Professor Hubble rubbed and soothed. He

worked quietly, kneeling beside Baggy, who had both eyes shut tight and his fingers crossed.

"All right Baggy," said the professor, "You can relax now, it's all over."

Baggy opened his eyes in wonder and looked with great curiosity at his side.

"My! that does feel-good," he said at last. "I didn't feel a thing."

"Now fill up your sack and we can get you off as soon as possible." said the

professor.

"Stand back now everybody, here goes," said Baggy.

He drew in his breath and it started to inflate his bag. Little by little, with

every breath, it got bigger and bigger and bigger. Soon he was well above the bushes and still growing.

Mrs Banks looked around nervously. Nobody had notices so far. The reporters were still asleep in their cars and there was no movement from the house.

Baggy then started blowing the air back out again.

"What are you doing that for?" questioned Mrs Banks.

"Just testing," he said "This is really good; very, very good. Yes I'd say it is just great. Look everybody - I'm cured!

"Shhhh?" said Mrs Banks nervously and Baggy carried on silently getting bigger and bigger.

"Oh Baggy!" called Bobby and ran forward "I'm going to miss you now, I might never ever see you again." He flung his arms around him as best he could.

"Nonsense!" said Baggy "I really will come and collect you one night. Bagbears don't forget so easily?"

"But not till next year," said the professor. "They will have forgotten all about you by then and moved onto something else. Nobody will bother you then if you are careful."

"Then a year from today it is," said Baggy.

"But do you promise?"

"Of course I do, Bagbears never break promises either. So don't worry it really isn't goodbye."

They gave each other a last hug and Baggy rose up into the night sky.

In a minute he was as high as the clouds and they could just make out his hand waving at them as he rose higher and higher. They all waved back and waved and waved till they could no longer see him.

Silently they began to shuffle back into the house. Mrs Banks had a lump in her throat. She thought of all the Bagbears looking out for Baggy to appear over the hills and she could just imagine how delighted they were going to be to have him back. She smiled contentedly as she put her arm around Bobby and gave him a kiss.

"Now we take care of the problem in our sitting room," she said.

They all crept quietly into the house and Mrs Banks opened the sitting room door. Matilda had done something right at last for she was curled up on the engineer's lap and her soft purring had lulled him off to sleep and he was snoring contentedly.

Chapter 11

When Nobody is Looking Anymore

Mrs Banks put her fingers to her lips and signalled to them to be very quiet. "Let's all get to bed and let him have a nice long sleep." They all nearly giggled but managed to stifle it just in time. The professor said a quick goodnight and slipped away without being seen and the family tip-toed out of the room, crept upstairs and went to bed..

Many hours later, while it was still dark, the engineer awoke with a start. He looked at his watch and leapt to his feet. He looked around and saw that everything looked quiet and normal and heaved a big sigh of relief. He then, very silently, went back outside to continue his work. He hadn't quite finished doing what he had to do when he got an angry call from his boss and it didn't make any sense at all.

The reporters then appeared again out of nowhere and started swarming around the house. The cameras were clicking, the phones were ringing and the Banks were not at all popular. They stood their ground and didn't say another word. Nobody could get a thing out of them.

They said things like, "it just vanished into thin air." And, "all we know is, it landed here and now it's gone!" Which was perfectly true!

Eventually, just as the professor had predicted, Bagbear and the Banks family became old news. The general opinion was that it was an elaborate, but not very convincing, hoax and people felt rather silly talking about it. They lost interest completely and moved on to something else.

Only the zoologists felt that it was worth keeping an eye on the Banks family but the tech company came back and took down the equipment from-the telegraph pole. They told the people from the zoo that they could never leave valuable equipment around for such an unimportant job.

After a while, even the zoologists began to say it was all a hoax and were quite annoyed that they had ever believed it and bit by bit the Banks family were left in peace.

Professor Hubble disappeared in the Himalayas whilst on a one man expedition and was given only two lines of space in the newspapers with absolutely no mention whatever of bagbears.

Bobby Banks went back to his studies at school and Miss Fotherington was almost nice to him.

Then one night, about a year after Baggy had left, Bobby turned on his radio and heard a very strange message.

> "Standby for Bannaboo ..... Plenty of room on board ..... All welcome."

That was all it said and made no sense to anybody except of course the Banks family

They immediately gave Matilda to a friend to be looked after for two weeks, stopped the milk, packed their suitcases, locked up their house and stood outside in their garden in the dead of night.

Out of a clear moonlit sky came three huge cloud-shaped objects. They landed in the garden and took off again in seconds with the entire Banks family safely aboard.

In Bannaboo that night there was a great re-union. Bagbears were floating in the sky once again to welcome the visitors.

On the ground, down in the green valley, the familiar figure of professor Hubble was dancing around with delight for he had gone to live there for good. He ran forward as they landed and greeted them like long-lost family members. Mrs Banks was the first one to jump down onto the grass. "Be careful Lorna," called Mr. Banks after her. Lorna gave him a reassuring wave. "It's fine Flyn. We are among friends here." She laughed a little and opened her arms wide to welcome the Professor's hug.

"Let me introduce myself properly," he said, after his bear-sized welcome. "My name is George; George Henry Alexander Hubble."

"Very pleased to meet you, once again, George! What on earth are you doing here?"

"Simple, I live here now. Also, I am learning new things every day and teaching them about people. Letting them know about the good things as well as the bad things." He looked very serious for a moment.

Flyn came over to join them and shook George's hand vigourously. "Good choice," he said as he pointed to their surroundings.

The professor nodded and continued. "You see," he said, "I believe that it is just a matter of time now, what with all this new tech that's about, that someone will discover these lovely folk. It may take a few years but they need to be ready. And they will need a good lawyer." He was pointing to himself as he said that.

"Lawyer?" said Flyn.

"Yes, erm, that is my other degree."

Lorna and Flyn were laughing with delight. "Fantastic!"

They turned to see Bobby and Baggy running together towards the caves.

The professor smiled. "Off to taste some Tikermottle-Glory I suspect. Would you like to come and see the city?"

They walked towards the opening in the mountain side and followed him in. Behind them, was a whole line of young Bagbears. They had been told not to bother Bobby's parents but they couldn't help chattering. It was pretty noisy!

The next few weeks were the best holiday of their lives. Snow-boarding down the mountain side, wrapped snug and warm on Bagbear tummies. Floating with them, around neighbouring mountains. They even visited the Yetties. They were a rather solemn lot, with a serious sense of humour. They had met the professor several times and were glad that someone was taking them 'seriously' at last. (They loved that word).

But the best fun they had was listing to the Bagbears telling their stories and sitting around the fire at night eating Heuch Buns, covered with Heuchberry sauce and washing it all down with their Fizzing Filliat Juice.

Luckily, Lorna had managed to save a few packets of peanut butter cookies and shared the recipe with the bears.

'Ah! Fumpie Nuts" exclaimed the bear cook. "They grow in some valleys here. Perfect!" In no time at all, 'FUMPIE NUT COOKIES' were being added to the feasts. Lorna noticed a few interesting additions to them. Perfect, she thought. "Just what they needed."

It was sad to leave, but it was time to go. It helped to know they would certainly be going back again. The bears had promised and they ALWAYS keep their promise!

They arrived back home, safe and sound, refreshed and feeling very happy. They had no holiday snaps! All the pictures and memories were safe and sound in their heads. They just smiled sweetly when neighbours asked them about their holidays. "Yes, they would say. Just visited family."

Life in the Banks' house returned back to normal; except for some small things.

Lorna Banks was nearly always smiling and often hummed very strange tunes. She started selling her new improved peanut butter cookies to her friend's bakery. They became very popular. So popular in fact that she gave up her part-time job at the supermarket and started her own little 'peanut cookie bakery' at home.

Flyn Banks, immediately entered agricultural collage. He gave up his office job and went to work in a garden centre. He was still very down to earth and practical but smiled a lot, lot more.

Bobby still went to school. But he studied much harder. He wanted to know EVERYTHING.! (Or at least, a bit more)

. . .

THE END.

(Or maybe, just the beginning)